

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN PUERTO RICO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Puerto Rico rests on something this island has proven it possesses: the power of an organised community to win. This is a Caribbean archipelago that is a United States territory, whose people are US citizens, and whose recent history holds two landmark demonstrations of community environmental victory. This is a Caribbean archipelago that is an unincorporated United States territory, whose people are US citizens by birth, and whose recent history holds two landmark and internationally-known demonstrations of community environmental victory — the movement that forced the US Navy to stop bombing Vieques, and the mountain town that beat back open-pit mining and then built its own solar future. The years-long movement that forced the US Navy to stop bombing the island of Vieques, and the mountain town of Adjuntas that beat back open-pit mining and then built its own community-owned solar future. That proven capacity — to organise, to litigate, to hold federal agencies and private utilities to account, and to build alternatives from below — is the distinctive ground of environmental effort here, because Puerto Rico, for all the constraints of its territorial status, possesses the genuine tools of a working, rights-bearing civil society: courts, a free press, federal environmental agencies, a deep organising tradition, and a vast mainland diaspora. Puerto Rico is a densely populated Caribbean island of mountains, karst, coast, and coral, dependent on an imported-fossil-fuel grid that collapsed in Hurricane Maria, exposed to worsening storms, and marked by the legacy of decades of military use and industrial pollution. Puerto Rico is a densely populated Caribbean archipelago of mountains, northern limestone karst, coast, and coral reefs, dependent on an imported-fossil-fuel grid that collapsed in Hurricane Maria and remains fragile through the storms since. dependent on an aging, imported-fossil-fuel grid that collapsed catastrophically in Hurricane Maria and has remained fragile through every storm since, exposed to worsening hurricanes and sea-level rise, and marked by the legacy of decades of military use on Vieques and the industrial pollution of its southern coast. and marked by the legacy of decades of US Navy bombing on Vieques and the industrial pollution of the fence-line communities of its southern coast. This guide will be honest that the grid's troubled privatisation, the fossil interests, and the slow federal funding make the energy transition a hard fight; that a federal fiscal-control board constrains the island's own planning; that the Vieques cleanup drags on and militarisation looms again; that outside capital and tax incentives drive coastal development and gentrification; and that the transition itself carries justice pitfalls; but it will show that the levers here — the grid and energy justice, Vieques and the military legacy, the coal ash and the south, the coast and karst, and the community, legal, federal, and diaspora channels — are real, powerful, and, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo proved, genuinely winnable.

The Puerto Rican story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Puerto Rican, and it is what gives this guide its particular force. **Because the energy transition can be pressed through the island's own renewable law and its proven community solar, because Vieques shows a community can force even the US Navy out and the cleanup can be pressed, because the coal ash and pollution can be reached through federal environmental law, because the coast and karst can be defended, and because the organising tradition, the courts, the federal agencies, and the diaspora genuinely work,**

the levers run through community power and the law: the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels. That combination — the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in a US territory with a proven organising tradition and access to federal environmental law, the strongest ground is the community power and the legal and federal levers that Vieques and Casa Pueblo showed can win.

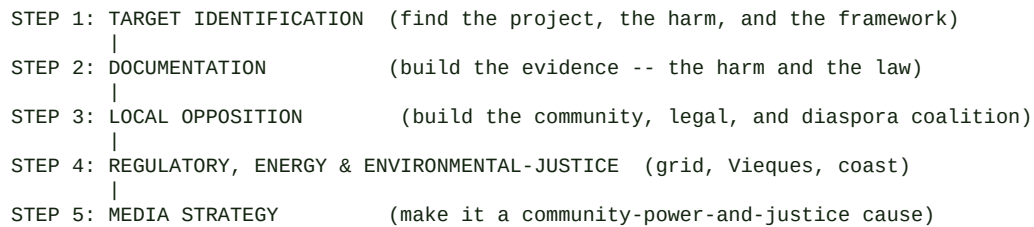
But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The privatisation is contested, the fiscal board constrains, the cleanup drags, gentrification presses, and the status limits.** The grid's privatisation and the fossil interests make the transition a hard fight; the federal fiscal-control board constrains the island's own planning and funding; the Vieques cleanup is slow and militarisation returns; outside capital and tax incentives drive coastal gentrification; the territorial status limits self-determination; and even the transition carries justice pitfalls, such as poorly-sited solar. This guide does not pretend the fight is easy, or that the status does not constrain, or that the transition is without its own hazards. What it shows is how, through the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels, Puerto Ricans — the communities, the organisers, the lawyers, the scientists, and the diaspora — can defend the energy future, the land, the coast, and the health of the people, powerfully and through the genuine channels this proven civil society affords.

Most people who care about Puerto Rico's environment do not know HOW to use the levers a US territory with a proven organising tradition offers. They see the blackouts, the coal ash, the eroding coast, the slow Vieques cleanup — and either despair of the status and the fiscal board, or protest without the full set of levers, and rarely grasp what Vieques and Casa Pueblo proved: that community power, the courts, the federal agencies, and the diaspora can genuinely win. The gap between the coast defended and the coast lost is here often a gap of method — the method of using the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels together, as the winning movements did.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Puerto Rican reality as it is, which is a US Caribbean territory with a proven organising tradition, access to federal environmental law, and real, recent environmental victories. It is written for the person — in a community, in the island's vibrant civil society, among its lawyers and scientists, or in its vast diaspora — who sees the grid and Vieques and the coast and wants to know what can be done in a territory that has proven it can win. The answer is a strong yes: the levers are real and powerful — the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels — with the honest qualifiers that the privatisation is contested, the fiscal board constrains, the cleanup drags, gentrification presses, and the status limits, so the work is community-based, legal, federal, and diaspora-borne, and, as Vieques proved, can win. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used, because the Puerto Rican case is, encouragingly, among the most hopeful in this series. It is for the person — in a fenceline or coastal community, in the island's vibrant civil society, among its lawyers and scientists, or in its vast diaspora — ready to take up the proven tools of a rights-bearing civil society: community organising, litigation, federal environmental law, a free press, and diaspora advocacy, in the tradition of the movements that have already won. That is the right spirit here, because the levers that deliver — the renewable law, the community solar, the federal environmental law, the courts, the organising power, the diaspora — are genuinely available and genuinely winning, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo proved. Anyone who approaches Puerto Rico by despairing at the status or the fiscal board will miss the real and proven power that its rights and its organising tradition afford; anyone who approaches it through community power, the law, and the federal channels, in the tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo, can genuinely help win the energy future, the cleanup, and the coast. This guide is an honest map of that proven, winning path.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to a US territory with a proven organising tradition:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of the harm and the law feeds the energy fight, the Vieques cleanup, and the coastal defence at once; the community, legal, and diaspora coalition organises; a regulatory challenge, a Superfund push, or a community-solar effort is both pressure and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best chance of defending the energy future, the land, and the coast — as the winning movements did.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Puerto Rico's — a US territory with a proven organising tradition — give a distinctive set:

- **The grid.** The **energy transition** can be pressed through the island's own renewable law and its proven community solar — the distinctive lever.
- **Vieques.** The **Vieques legacy** shows a community can force even the US Navy out, and the cleanup can be pressed.
- **The coal ash.** The **coal ash and pollution** can be reached through federal environmental law and the community environmental-justice movement.
- **The coast.** The **coast, karst, and development** can be defended through the coastal and public-access law.
- **The channels.** The **organising tradition, the courts, the federal agencies, and the diaspora** genuinely work and have won.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers always prevail, or that the status does not constrain, or that the transition is without hazard. The privatisation is **contested**; the fiscal board **constrains**; the cleanup **drags**; gentrification **presses**; and the status **limits**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it works through community power, the law, and the federal channels — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels — to defend the energy future, the land, and the coast, honestly acknowledging the contested privatisation, the constraining fiscal board, the dragging cleanup, the pressing gentrification, and the limiting status.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here, encouragingly, you must see that the levers run through genuine and powerful channels: the island's own renewable law and energy regulator, the federal environmental agencies and courts, the deep community-organising tradition, and the vast diaspora, because Puerto Rico, for all its territorial constraints, possesses the real tools of a rights-bearing civil society, and has used them to win. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides a project's

fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels apply, because in Puerto Rico a destructive project is met not by despair at the status, but through the energy law and regulator, the federal environmental process, the courts, and the organised community that Vieques and Casa Pueblo proved can win.

The Levels of Decision

A Puerto Rican project runs through an island government, a federal overlay, and a powerful civil society.

The island government and the energy bodies. The **Commonwealth government, the energy bureau, and the utilities** decide much, under the island's own laws, including the renewable-energy commitment.

The federal agencies and the fiscal board. The **US federal environmental agencies, the federal funders, and the fiscal-control board** hold real power over the environment, the funding, and the planning — agencies to be pressed, a board to be reckoned with.

The courts and the regulators. The **courts, both local and federal, and the energy and environmental regulators** offer genuine legal and regulatory avenues, as the movements have used.

The community and civil society. The **communities, the organising groups, the environmental-justice movement, and the free press** hold the proven power that won Vieques and built Casa Pueblo.

The diaspora and the wider frameworks. The **vast mainland diaspora, the mainland allies, and the national environmental organisations** carry a reach and a voice a territory's own numbers do not.

The Journey of a Project

A Puerto Rican project — a fossil-grid decision, a coal-ash discharge, a stalled Vieques cleanup, a coastal development — is met through the **grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels**. **The grid and Vieques are where the landmark fights are waged, and the coal ash, the coast, and the channels are what carry the effort** — and using them together, through community power and the law, is the distinctive Puerto Rican approach. The distinctive levers are the **grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what energy future, land, coast, or community is at stake, what law or framework applies, and how the community, the courts, the federal agencies, and the diaspora can be brought to bear**, because those are where a project can genuinely be met — and won.

Follow the Project, the Harm, and the Law

Behind a project stand the utilities, the developers, the federal agencies, and the energy future, land, coast, and communities at stake. Trace who decides, who benefits, what is harmed, and — importantly here — **what energy future, land, coast, or community is threatened, what law, regulation, or federal framework applies, what community and legal avenues exist, and how the organising tradition, the courts, the agencies, and the diaspora can act**. Two questions unlock most Puerto Rican efforts: **What is harmed, and what law or framework reaches it?** and **Which lever — the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, the channels — can meet it?** The community power, the law, and the federal agencies are, together, the heart of most such efforts here — as the winning movements showed. Everything else in a Puerto Rican effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to establish the harm and the law on the public and enforceable record; the community-legal-and-diaspora coalition exists to press that case through the regulators, the courts, the federal agencies, and the streets; and the free and diaspora media exists to reach the island, the mainland, and the Congress with the justice of the cause. Keep the community power, the law, and the federal agencies at the centre of every case, campaign, and story, and the effort

retains a clear spine that runs from a single fenceline household or a single stretch of eroding coast to the enforceable renewable and environmental law and the proven organising power, grounding the whole in the community power and the law through which a US territory with a proud organising tradition has won, and can win again.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a project, because they are the levers. The **island government and energy bodies**; the **federal agencies and the fiscal board**; the **courts and regulators**; the **community and civil society**; and the **diaspora and wider frameworks**. In Puerto Rico, the **grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a fossil-grid decision, a coal-ash discharge, a stalled cleanup, or a coastal development can genuinely be met — through the energy law, the federal process, the courts, and the organised community — though, honestly, the privatisation is contested, the fiscal board constrains, the cleanup drags, gentrification presses, and the status limits, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep working through community power, the law, and the federal channels, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo did.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here the honest calibration is genuinely hopeful, because Puerto Rico has proven, in Vieques and Casa Pueblo, that community power and the law can win, even as the privatisation, the fiscal board, and the status make the fights hard. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how environmental efforts tend to go in US territories with proven organising traditions, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the harm can be **tied to a law, a federal framework, or the renewable commitment**, whether the **community, legal, and diaspora avenues** can be engaged, and whether the **federal agencies and funders** can be brought to bear. Where the harm is documented and the channels used, the levers here are real and often winnable, as Vieques proved; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the privatisation is contested, the fiscal board constrains, and the status limits.

Individual Step Success Rates

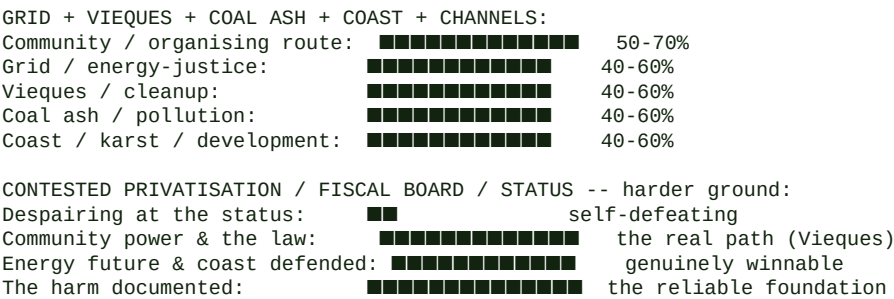
Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	20–30%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Grid / energy-justice	40–60%	months–years	low–moderate	The transition pressed, community solar advanced
Vieques / cleanup	40–60%	years	low	The cleanup pressed, the legacy addressed
Coal ash / pollution	40–60%	months–years	low	The pollution reached through federal law
Coast / karst / development	40–60%	months–years	low	The coast and karst defended, access upheld
Community / organising route	50–70%	months	low	The community power mobilised, as it has won
Legal / federal route	40–60%	months–years	low–moderate	The courts and agencies engaged

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
All levers together	45–65%	years	moderate	Energy future, land, and coast defended

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Puerto Rico's real strength is its proven community power and its access to the law: the **grid**, **Vieques**, the **coal ash**, the **coast**, and the **channels**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the privatisation is **contested**, the fiscal board **constrains**, the cleanup **drags**, gentrification **presses**, and the status **limits** — but the organising tradition, the federal environmental law, and the diaspora make the odds here genuinely favourable, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo proved.

*A note on cost and risk: most levers here — a regulatory challenge, a community-solar effort, a Superfund push, a coastal case — can be pursued openly and lawfully, drawing on the courts, the federal agencies, the free press, and the organising tradition. The scarce resources are **the legal and technical capacity, the community and organising links, and the diaspora and mainland connections** — much of it reachable through the environmental-justice groups, the energy bureau, the federal agencies, the national environmental organisations, and the vast diaspora. This shapes where a Puerto Rican effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are legal and technical capacity, community and organising strength, and diaspora and mainland connection — all of which the island genuinely possesses and has used to win — an effort's most valuable investments are in building the legal and evidentiary case, deepening the community organising, cultivating the diaspora and national relationships, and grounding the whole in the enforceable renewable and environmental law. A capable, well-organised, well-connected effort that can marshal the public and agency record, mobilise the proven community power, wield the federal environmental law, and enlist the diaspora can achieve real, landmark victories in this territory, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo did, and can do so openly and lawfully. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of legal skill, organising strength, and diaspora reach — much of it reachable through the environmental-justice groups, the energy bureau, the federal agencies, the national environmental organisations, and the vast diaspora. And because Puerto Rico has proven it can win — at Vieques, at Adjuntas — the community power and the law are the most telling levers, and they are genuinely available.*

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Puerto Rico are **the community and organising route, the grid and energy-justice fight, the Vieques and cleanup effort, and the coal-ash and coastal cases** — used together, with the legal and federal routes throughout. The community, grid, and Vieques levers show the ceiling, which is genuinely high: a proven organising tradition, the island's own renewable law, and the federal environmental process can and have won real victories. The contested privatisation, the fiscal board, and the status show the honest floor: the fights are hard and the constraints real. Most Puerto Rican efforts will sit between, but higher than in most places, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real and often winnable — the community power, the law, the federal agencies — but

that despairing at the status is self-defeating, and the surest result is that the harm is documented and pressed through the community, the law, and the federal channels.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The community organising and the grid fight** — Puerto Rico's distinctive strengths; the proven power and the live energy transition.
2. **The Vieques legacy and the federal environmental law** — the landmark precedent and the federal levers.
3. **The coal ash and coastal cases** — the environmental-justice and coastal fights.
4. **The diaspora and the courts** — the reach and the legal avenues.
5. **The documented harm and law** — the evidence that grounds it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **Vieques proved a community can force out even the US Navy** — a landmark, real win. **Casa Pueblo proved a town can beat mining and build its own solar** — another. **The renewable law and rooftop solar are real** — the transition has momentum. **Federal environmental law reaches the pollution** — a genuine lever. **But the privatisation, the fiscal board, and the status constrain** — so the work is community-based, legal, and federal. The through-line: **document the harm and the law; press the energy transition through the renewable law and community solar; press the Vieques cleanup and address the legacy; reach the coal ash and pollution through federal law; defend the coast, karst, and access; use the community, legal, federal, and diaspora channels; and draw on the proven power** — because an effort that does can genuinely defend the energy future, the land, and the coast, and, as Vieques showed, win, while being honest that the privatisation is contested, the fiscal board constrains, and the status limits.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project and harm — and the leverage, which here runs through the energy law, the federal environmental process, the courts, and the community. Vague concern goes nowhere; an effort aimed at "this project harming this energy future, land, coast, or community, which the renewable law, the federal environmental process, or the courts can meet" is a real, workable, often winnable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **What is harmed?** This is the first question here. What **energy future, land, coast, or community** is harmed — the grid and the transition, the Vieques land, the air and water, the coast, the karst, the health.
2. **What law or framework applies?** What **island law (the renewable commitment), federal environmental law, or Superfund framework** reaches the harm.
3. **Is it the grid, Vieques, or the coast?** Whether the matter is one of the **grid and energy justice, Vieques and the legacy, or the coal ash, coast, and land** — for each has its levers.
4. **What community and legal avenue exists?** What **community, regulatory, federal-agency, or court avenue** the matter opens.

5. How can the community, courts, and diaspora act? How the **community, the lawyers, the federal agencies, and the diaspora** can act — powerfully, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo did.

A Worked Example

Suppose a decision would lock the island back into fossil generation, or delay the renewable transition, against the island's own 100%-renewable law and the proven promise of community solar.

Working the five questions: **what is harmed? What law applies? Is it the grid, Vieques, or the coast? What avenue exists?** And how can the community, courts, and diaspora act? The driver is the fossil-grid decision and the renewable law, with the energy-justice movement, the regulator, and the community solar as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the grid is the utility's business and nothing can be done" to a real effort: document the decision against the renewable law; press the energy bureau and the regulator; advance the rooftop and community solar the model towns have proven; enlist the federal funders and the courts; and mobilise the community and diaspora. That is a workable effort suited to Puerto Rico — one that presses the energy transition through the island's own law, the community solar, and the federal and legal channels, as the movements have done. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight in a US territory with a proven organising tradition: they turn what might seem an overwhelming set of forces — a bankrupt utility, a privatisation, a fiscal board, a fossil grid — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that rests on the island's own renewable law, the enforceable federal environmental law, and the proven community power, rather than on a despair at the status. The harm becomes a documentable departure from the renewable law, a coal-ash violation, a stalled cleanup, a coastal threat. The law becomes the enforceable ground — the renewable commitment, the federal environmental law, the Superfund process. The category becomes the grid, Vieques, or the coast, each with its levers. The avenue becomes the regulator, the federal agency, the court, or the community. And the channels become the community, the lawyers, the agencies, and the diaspora, in the open. That translation — from an overwhelming set of forces into a set of specific, law-grounded, community-powered actions — is the first and most important thing a Puerto Rican effort does, because it moves the fight from the despair of the status onto the firm ground of enforceable law and proven community power, where, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo showed, landmark victories are genuinely won.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here a well-documented case has genuine legal, regulatory, and federal channels to win through, as Vieques did. A regulator, a federal agency, a court, the community, and the diaspora all move on evidence — and in Puerto Rico, a clear record of the harm and the law that reaches it is precisely what a community and legal effort turns into a real, winnable result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Harm, and the Law

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project and the harm** — the fossil-grid decision, the coal-ash discharge, the stalled cleanup, the coastal development — and, decisively here, **the energy future, land, coast, or community it harms and the law that reaches it**: the renewable commitment, the federal environmental law, the Superfund framework, the coastal law. Establish exactly **what the project is, what it harms, and what law reaches it**, because the harm-against-the-law is the case's foundation.

Layer 2: The Harm, the Science, and the Impact

Document the harm with the science. Establish the **environmental and health harm** — the emissions, the coal ash, the contamination, the coastal loss, the health impacts — drawing on **the energy and environmental data, the federal agency records, the scientific and health studies, and the community's own knowledge**. This harm-and-impact evidence turns the concern into a documented case the regulators, the federal agencies, and the courts can act on.

Layer 3: The Case, the Law, the Channel, and the Community

Finally, document the case and the path. Does the **harm** breach the renewable law, the federal environmental law, or the Superfund and coastal frameworks? What **law or framework** applies? Which **regulator, federal agency, court, or community avenue** will act? And how will the **community, legal, and diaspora power** be brought to bear? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case the channels can act on — and win. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented harm, an applicable law, a genuine channel, and a mobilised community are exactly what let a Puerto Rican effort defend the energy future, the land, and the coast, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo did. Build it well, and the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels become the effort's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: because Puerto Rico is a US territory with enforceable environmental law, active federal agencies, a free press, and a great deal of scientific and investigative attention, a remarkable amount of the necessary evidence already exists in the public record and is genuinely obtainable. The EPA's inspections and violations at the coal plant, the Energy Bureau's investigations of the grid and the utilities, the DOE's studies of the renewable path, the Superfund records for Vieques, the coastal and karst studies, and the reporting of a vigorous free press are all, in large part, matters of public record. This is a very different situation from the closed or fragile states elsewhere in this series, where evidence must be gathered warily and at risk. Here, an effort can often build its case substantially from the existing public, agency, and scientific record, joined to the community's own documentation, using the open-records and environmental laws that a US territory provides. Building this layer well therefore means marshalling that rich public record — the agency findings, the studies, the reporting — and joining it to the community's knowledge, so that the case rests on a solid, public, and legally enforceable foundation.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here, in a US territory with federal environmental law and a free press, much of it is genuinely obtainable through public records, agency data, and the courts. Here is where the material tends to live in a Puerto Rican effort, and how to get it — with the **harm, the law, the science, and the community** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Project, Harm, and Law Record

Start with the project and the law. **The project and utility records, the environmental filings, and the federal agency documents** establish the project and the harm; the distinctive strengths here are the **island's own renewable law** and the **federal environmental law and its public records**, both genuine and enforceable. Establish the **project, the harm, and the law that reaches it**, drawing on the utility, regulatory, and federal records. Establish exactly **what is planned, what it harms, and what law reaches it**, because a harm that breaches an enforceable law is strong, winnable ground.

The Harm, Science, and Impact Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **harm evidence** — the emissions, the coal ash, the contamination, the coastal loss, the health impacts — and the **science** — drawing on **the energy and environmental data, the federal agency records (including EPA violations and studies), the scientific and health research, and the community's own documentation**. This harm-and-science evidence is what turns the concern into a documented case the regulators and courts can act on.

The Law, Framework, and Federal Record

Document the levers of the law. Gather the record of **the island's renewable-energy law and the energy bureau; the federal environmental law, the EPA, and the Superfund and coastal frameworks; and the federal funding programmes and the fiscal board's constraints**. A community and its allies that understand the renewable law, the federal environmental law, and the funding hold the levers that Vieques and Casa Pueblo used to win.

The Community, Legal, and Diaspora Record

Document the wider levers. Gather the record of the **community and organising groups, the environmental-justice movement, and the free press**; the **lawyers and the national environmental organisations**; and the **vast diaspora and the mainland allies**. A community joined to the lawyers, the national organisations, and the diaspora holds levers that reach from the island community to the federal courts and the mainland — as the winning movements did.

The People, the Power, and the Justice

Finally, map the human terrain, which in Puerto Rico is a proven strength. Who is affected — the **fenceline and coastal communities, the Vieques residents, the ratepayers, and the future generations** — and who can act: the **communities and organisers, the lawyers, the federal agencies, and the diaspora**. And how does the effort **draw on the proven organising power and the environmental-justice frame**? A Puerto Rican effort is advanced through the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels — so map that coalition deliberately, draw on the power that won Vieques, and let the community and the justice of the cause carry the effort.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step draws on one of the strongest organising traditions in the hemisphere, because Puerto Rico has proven — in Vieques, in Adjuntas, in the coal-ash south, in the streets — that an organised community can win landmark environmental victories, even against the US Navy and the fossil utilities. The task is to build a coalition — of communities, organisers, lawyers, and the diaspora — that defends the energy future, the land, and the coast, through community power and the law.

Why the Community-Legal-and-Diaspora Coalition Is Decisive

In Puerto Rico, the coalition that wins joins the communities and organisers to the lawyers and the diaspora, because a US territory with a proven organising tradition, federal environmental law, and a vast mainland diaspora responds to community power, legal pressure, and national attention — as Vieques and Casa Pueblo proved. That coalition supplies what a winning effort runs on: the communities and organisers whose power forced out the Navy and built the solar, the lawyers and national organisations who wield the federal environmental law, the free press, and the diaspora who carry the fight to the mainland and the Congress.

When communities, lawyers, and the diaspora press together, they become a genuine and often winning force. **A coalition that joins community power, the law, and the diaspora here is not a hopeful aspiration but a proven, winning formula — the real foundation of a Puerto Rican effort, defending the energy future and the coast as Vieques and Casa Pueblo did.** This is worth dwelling on, because it marks the deepest difference between a Puerto Rican effort and one waged in a closed or fragile state, and it is grounded not in theory but in demonstrated history. In many nations, those who oppose a destructive project must work warily, from outside, or against a state that can silence them; in Puerto Rico, the community can organise in the open, litigate in real courts, invoke enforceable federal environmental law, mobilise a free press, and draw on a diaspora that outnumbers the island's own population and votes in the mainland states and the Congress. And it has done all of this to win: the Vieques movement, over years, turned the bombing of an American community into a national scandal and forced the world's most powerful navy to leave; Casa Pueblo, in the mountains of Adjuntas, first defeated a mining project and then built a solar model that kept its lights on when the whole island went dark. The task, therefore, is to assemble that same proven coalition — community power, legal skill, federal leverage, and diaspora reach — because it is not an untested hope but a formula that has already delivered landmark victories, and because the combination of a rights-bearing civil society and enforceable environmental law gives a Puerto Rican effort a genuine and often winning chance that few in this series possess.

Finding the Coalition

Begin with those the project touches and those who can act — the **fenceline and coastal communities, the organising groups, the environmental-justice movement, the lawyers, and the diaspora** — for open, powerful organising is not only possible here but proven. Widen to the wider public and the mainland allies. Name the shared stake — **our energy, our land, our coast, our health, and our self-determination in these matters** — because the energy and the land and the health are the shared inheritance and struggle of a people. Frame the effort around defending the energy future and the land and the coast, through community power and the law, as the winning movements did. There is real power in framing the cause this way, because it draws on the island's own deepest tradition and on the enforceable law that a US territory uniquely provides. A cause framed narrowly, or as a lament about the status, would forfeit both the broad coalition and the concrete legal and federal leverage that give the work its winning edge; a cause framed around the community's fight for a just energy future, the completion of the Vieques cleanup, the health of the fenceline communities, and the defence of the coast draws in the organisers, the lawyers, the federal agencies, the press, and the diaspora, in the proven tradition of the movements that have already won. This framing is not only the more powerful one; it is also the truer one, because the aim genuinely is the community's energy, land, health, and coast, defended through the very channels — community power and the law — that Vieques and Casa Pueblo used to win. An effort that names this frame precisely — the energy future, the land, and the coast, through community power and the law — stands on the strongest and most proven ground the Puerto Rican situation affords.

Coalition-Building, Through Community, Law, and Diaspora

A coalition allied is stronger than any single actor, and in Puerto Rico it is built through community power, the law, and the diaspora. Reach to the **communities and organising groups; the environmental-justice movement; the lawyers and national environmental organisations; the energy and environmental regulators and federal agencies; and the diaspora and mainland allies.** Frame the coalition around the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, and the coast. Build breadth through the community and the law, as Vieques did — for the coalition's strength is the proven union of community power, legal skill, and diaspora reach.

Sustaining the Effort

Puerto Rican efforts are sustained through community power, the law, and the diaspora. Keep the coalition **informed, connected, and mobilised**; mark real steps — a renewable milestone won, a cleanup advanced, a coal-ash violation enforced, a coast protected, a community-solar project built. And keep the effort grounded in the energy, the land, and the justice of the cause, which unite and endure. The effort that lasts is the one that draws on the proven organising power, joins the community to the lawyers and the diaspora, and uses the renewable law and the federal environmental process, as the winning movements did.

STEP 4: REGULATORY, ENERGY & ENVIRONMENTAL-JUSTICE CHALLENGES — THE GRID, VIEQUES, AND THE COAST

This is where a Puerto Rican effort is realistically and often victoriously advanced — through the **energy-justice fight for a renewable grid, the pressing of the Vieques cleanup and legacy, and the defence of the coast, the land, and the health** — in a territory with a proven organising tradition and access to federal environmental law. Here the grid, Vieques, and coast levers come together, because in Puerto Rico a destructive project can be met through community power, the renewable law, and the federal environmental process — and won.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth, which here is relatively hopeful. The levers are **real, powerful, and proven, though the privatisation, the fiscal board, and the status constrain**. The energy transition is **advancing through the renewable law and community solar, though the privatisation and fossil interests resist**; the Vieques legacy shows **a community can win, though the cleanup drags**; the coal ash and pollution are **reachable through federal law, though enforcement can be slow**; and the coast is **defensible, though gentrification presses**. What these levers realistically achieve is **the transition advanced, the cleanup pressed, the pollution reached, the coast defended, and the community empowered** — real, often winnable outcomes, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo proved. Enter this front with realistic confidence: the grid, Vieques, and the coast are Puerto Rico's distinctive levers, most powerful when **grounded in the law and the proven community power** — though the privatisation, the fiscal board, and the status constrain.

The Grid and Energy Justice

The first front is the grid and the just transition. The **fragile, fossil-dependent grid**, and the contested privatisation that followed Maria, can be pressed toward a **just, renewable, community-controlled energy future** — through the island's own 100%-renewable law, the proven rooftop and community solar (as at Adjuntas), the federal funding for resilience and solar, the energy regulator, and the legal and community pressure on the utilities — while guarding against the transition's own pitfalls, such as poorly-sited utility-scale solar that would burden the very communities it should serve. Use the grid and energy justice, because the island's own law commits it to renewable power, the community solar has proven itself the most dependable in the storms, and the federal funding and the regulator offer real levers — a transition that must be not only renewable but just, distributed, and community-controlled. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this grid front, honestly, for it is the most distinctive and live lever a Puerto Rican effort holds. Its power is real and proven: the island is legally committed to fully renewable power, rooftop and community solar have already shown themselves the most dependable source through the storms, tens of thousands of households have adopted them, the federal government has committed real resilience and

solar funding, and the energy regulator and the courts offer genuine avenues. Its limits are equally real and must be named honestly: the privatised utilities and the fossil interests resist, the fiscal board and the slow, contested federal funding constrain the pace, and the transition itself can be captured — poorly-sited utility-scale solar can flood and burden the very southern communities it should serve. Understanding both means using the grid front for what it does best — pressing the renewable law, advancing the distributed and community-controlled solar the storms proved dependable, and directing the federal funding to just ends — while guarding vigilantly against a transition that is renewable in name but unjust in fact, so that the energy future won is one that serves the communities rather than merely relocating the burden onto them.

Vieques and the Military Legacy

The second front is Vieques. The **legacy of decades of Navy bombing** — the contamination, the unexploded ordnance, the health concerns, and the slow, unfinished cleanup — can be pressed through the **Superfund and federal-agency process, the community and legal pressure that won the Navy's ouster, and the environmental-justice frameworks**, even as the renewed militarisation of the region is watched and contested on environmental grounds. Use Vieques and the legacy, because the community already achieved the landmark victory of forcing the Navy out, and that same community power and legal pressure can be turned to press the cleanup the ouster was meant to secure — a demonstrated capacity to win, applied to the unfinished work.

The Coal Ash, the Coast, and the Land

The third front is the coal ash, the coast, and the land. The **coal ash and pollution of the industrial south** can be reached through the **federal environmental law and the fenceline environmental-justice movement**, pressing the just retirement of the coal plant and the remediation of the ash; and the **eroding coast, the development and gentrification, the karst and aquifers, and the fragile bays** can be defended through the **coastal and public-access law, the maritime-zone protections, and community organising**. Press the coal ash, the coast, and the land, because the fenceline communities bear a pollution federal law can reach, and the coast and karst are the island's threatened commons — defended, as ever here, through the law and the organised community. Pursued together — the grid, Vieques, and the coast — these fronts are how a Puerto Rican effort defends the energy future, the land, and the coast, through community power and the law, as the winning movements did. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in Puerto Rico's particular situation. The grid front presses the just, renewable transition through the island's own law and its proven community solar. The Vieques front turns a demonstrated capacity to win — the forcing-out of the Navy — to the unfinished cleanup and the watching of renewed militarisation. And the coal-ash-and-coast front reaches the pollution and the coastal threats through the federal environmental law and the fenceline and coastal communities. Each covers the others' reach: the grid at the level of the island's energy law, Vieques at the level of the federal cleanup and the proven precedent, and the coal ash and coast at the level of the federal environmental law and the local commons. And each strengthens the others, for the same organising power and legal skill that press the grid press the cleanup and defend the coast, the same federal agencies reach the ash and the Vieques legacy, and the same diaspora amplifies them all. An effort that grasps this mutual reinforcement, and pursues each front together, makes the fullest use of the several community, legal, and federal levers that a US territory with a proven organising tradition uniquely provides — and that Vieques and Casa Pueblo proved can win.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of harm and law becomes different arguments for the island government, the federal agencies, the regulators, the courts, and the community and diaspora. Translate deliberately.

For the Island Government and Energy Bodies

The island government and energy bodies respond to **the island's own laws, the public, and the resilience**. Frame the harm as a departure from the island's own renewable commitment and the public's demand for reliable power: here is the fossil decision, the renewable law it strains, the community solar that works, the public will. Give them the documented harm and the law, and press for the renewable, resilient, community-controlled path. Make it concrete: *here is your own renewable law, here is the community solar that kept the lights on in Maria, here is the path that honours both*. This is the argument a government answerable to its people must weigh.

For the Federal Agencies

The federal agencies respond to **the federal environmental law and their own mandates**. Frame the harm as a matter for the EPA, the Superfund process, or the federal funders: here is the coal ash, the contamination, the violation, the framework. Give them the evidence, and press for enforcement, cleanup, and funding. A federal agency with the evidence and the mandate can act, as at Vieques and the coal plant.

For the Regulators and Courts

The regulators and courts respond to **the law, the record, and the rights**. Frame the harm as a breach of the renewable law, the environmental law, or the coastal law: here is the harm, the law, the record, the remedy. Give them the legal case, and pursue the regulatory and court avenues. The energy bureau, the regulators, and the courts, engaged with a strong case, are genuine and often winning avenues.

For the Community, Diaspora, and Public

The community, diaspora, and public respond to **the justice, the health, and the self-determination**. Translate the file into the story of a community's energy, land, and health: here is the fenceline, the coast, the grid, the justice at stake. Frame it as the community's fight for its energy future and its health, in the tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo. Keep it accurate and rooted in the community; and speak to the diaspora's commitment and the public's justice.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, and use the law and the community power fully. Your credibility rests on the real harm and the real law — the community power and the legal case, in the proven tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo. State the harm precisely, tie it to the renewable law, the federal environmental law, or the coastal law, and press through the community, the regulators, the federal agencies, and the courts. An effort that is precise, law-grounded, and community-powered is powerful in Puerto Rico — and here, as Vieques proved, it can win.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and here, with a free press, a globally resonant story, and a vast mainland diaspora, media is a genuine and powerful lever, as the Vieques movement showed when it reached the mainland and the Congress. The story — a US territory fighting for a just energy future, pressing an unfinished military cleanup, and defending its coast — resonates on the island,

on the mainland, and beyond.

Why Media Matters

The island government, the federal agencies, the utilities, and the mainland public behave differently when the harm and the justice of the cause are visible. Media does three things here: it **informs and mobilises the community and the diaspora**, it **raises the stakes** for a government and utilities answerable to the public and for federal agencies answerable to the mainland, and it **reaches the national media, the Congress, and the public** — as Vieques did, when the bombing of an American community became a national story. The free press, the resonant cause, and the vast diaspora make media a real and powerful channel. Media is among the strongest levers a Puerto Rican effort holds.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the community and the justice. The strongest frame is concrete and resonant: *a community of US citizens fighting for a reliable, renewable energy future after the longest blackout in US history, pressing the cleanup of land bombed for sixty years, and defending its coast — in the proven tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo*. Put the community's fight and the justice first, because the story of American citizens denied reliable power and clean land is powerful and resonant, on the island and the mainland alike. Keep it scrupulously accurate and rooted in the community. The Puerto Rican story is powerful because the cause is just, the community proven, and the diaspora vast.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience. **The island press and community networks** for the community; **the national and diaspora media** for the mainland and the Congress; **the environmental-justice and energy media** for the movement; and **community and organising networks** for the mobilisation. Because the press is free, the cause resonant, and the diaspora vast, both the island and the mainland channels are open and powerful — the just cause and the proven community are the story's power, as Vieques showed.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, rooted, and constructive — the aim is the energy future, the cleanup, and the coast, grounded in the law and the community, and framed around the environment and the justice of the cause. Frame the story around the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, and the coast, and handle the status question, the militarisation, and the partisan politics factually and with care, keeping the focus on the environment and the community. And sustain the story across the long fights. Above all, let the community's fight, the just cause, and the proven tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo carry the story, because that is where a Puerto Rican effort is strongest.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real law, keep it factual and community-rooted, and use the channels fully. Here the renewable law, the federal environmental law, and the community power, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for public records — [project] and its environmental impact

To [energy bureau / agency / utility],

I am writing on behalf of [community / group] regarding [the project] and its effects on [the grid / land / coast / community]. Under the applicable public-records and environmental laws, I respectfully request the **environmental filings and assessments**, the **permits and compliance records**, and the **relevant studies** for the project.

I would be grateful for a response within the legal period.

Respectfully,

[Name, community / group, contact]

8B: The Grid / Energy-Justice Case

Subject: [Decision] and Puerto Rico's renewable-energy commitment

To [energy bureau / government],

The [fossil decision / delay] departs from Puerto Rico's own 100%-renewable commitment and from the community solar that proved most reliable after Maria. We respectfully urge the renewable, resilient, and community-controlled path, and the federal resilience and solar funding to achieve it. We attach the case.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: The Vieques / Cleanup Case

Subject: The unfinished cleanup of Vieques

To [EPA / Navy / federal agency],

The cleanup of the former Navy range on Vieques remains unfinished, and the contamination and its health impacts persist. We respectfully urge the acceleration and completion of the Superfund cleanup and the addressing of the legacy. We attach the record.

Respectfully,

[Name, Vieques community, contact]

8D: The Coal-Ash / Pollution Case

Subject: Coal ash and pollution at [location]

To [EPA / environmental agency],

The coal ash and pollution at [location] harm the fenceline community's air, water, and health, and appear to breach the federal environmental law. We respectfully urge enforcement, remediation, and the just retirement of the coal plant. We attach the violations and health evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: The Coast / Karst / Development Case

Subject: Defending the coast and karst at [location]

To [environmental agency / planning board],

The [development / erosion / quarrying] at [location] threatens the coast, the public access, or the karst and its aquifers. We respectfully urge protection through the coastal, maritime-zone, and public-access law. We attach the evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: To a National Organisation or the Diaspora

Subject: A Puerto Rican environmental fight that needs the mainland

Dear [national organisation / diaspora network],

We are fighting [the grid / Vieques / the coal ash / the coast], in the proven tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo, and we seek the mainland's legal, organising, and advocacy support. We respectfully ask your partnership in reaching the federal agencies, the Congress, and the national public. We provide the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: US citizens fighting for power, clean land, and a coast

Dear [journalist / editor],

In Puerto Rico, a community of US citizens is fighting for a reliable, renewable energy future after the longest blackout in US history, pressing the unfinished cleanup of Vieques, and defending its coast — in the tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo. There is a strong, resonant, national story here, and we can provide the records, the community's voices, and the environmental-justice dimension.

Sincerely,

[Name, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: We have won before — let us win again

Dear neighbours,

Our energy, our land, our coast, and our health face [the fossil grid / the coal ash / the stalled cleanup / the development]. But we are the people who forced the Navy out of Vieques and built our own solar in the mountains — and together, communities, organisers, lawyers, and our diaspora, by documenting the harm, pressing the law, and mobilising our proven power, we can win again. Please join us: share what you know, and add your voice.

With respect,

[Name, community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a project is acute — a fossil-grid contract advancing, a coal-ash discharge, a coastal development breaking ground, a cleanup deadline slipping — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest here, which means the community organising, the regulatory and legal challenge, and the federal environmental process.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what is harmed, and what law reaches it**. Identify the immediate harm — a **grid contract, a coal-ash discharge, a coastal build, a cleanup delay** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **community and organising groups, the lawyers, and the relevant regulator or federal agency** at once, because in Puerto Rico the community organising, the regulatory and legal challenge, and the federal environmental process are the fastest routes to real leverage.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The community organising** can mobilise quickly, as it always has here. **The regulatory challenge** can be filed fast with the energy or environmental bureau. **The federal agency** can be alerted fast to a violation. **The free press and the diaspora** can raise the alarm quickly. These outpace the slower work of the deep transition and cleanup — which continue alongside — because the community, the regulator, and the federal process can be brought to bear immediately. Above all, if a coal-ash discharge or a permit violation is occurring, alert the EPA and the regulator fast, because a federal environmental violation is a lever that can move quickly.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can mobilise the community, the lawyers, and the diaspora fast. Reach immediately to the **community and organising groups, the lawyers and national organisations, and the relevant agencies**. A coalition mobilising the community, filing the regulatory or legal challenge, and alerting the federal agencies is the most a rapid Puerto Rican effort can do — and, as Vieques showed, it can be powerful. Speed favours the prepared: know the harm, the law, and the channels before the crisis breaks, and draw on the proven organising power.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the field is tilted less by repression, which Puerto Rico's rights and courts prevent, than by the contested privatisation and the fossil and outside interests behind it, by a federal fiscal-control board that constrains the island's own planning, by the dependency and limits of territorial status, by the slowness of the federal funding and the cleanup, and by the way even the transition can be captured — as with poorly-sited utility-scale solar that burdens the very communities it should serve. Name it plainly, because pretending the privatisation is neutral, or that the fiscal board does not constrain, or that the transition has no pitfalls, would be false — but note, too, that the rights, the courts, the federal environmental law, and the proven organising power make this a field where community power and the law have won before and can win again.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **The privatisation is contested** — with fossil and outside interests behind it. **The fiscal board constrains** — the island's own planning and funding. **The status limits** — dependency and constrained self-determination. **The funding and cleanup are slow** — the recovery drags. **And even the transition can be captured** — poorly-sited solar burdening communities. But **the rights, the**

courts, the federal environmental law, and the proven organising power are real and winning levers. This is a tilt of contested privatisation, a fiscal board, and a constraining status, worked through community power, the law, and the federal process, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo did.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the levers of community power and the law. Lean on the **proven organising power** that won Vieques and Adjuntas; the **island's own renewable law**; the **federal environmental law and the courts**; the **federal funding**, pressed to flow to just and distributed ends; and the **diaspora and national attention**. Meet the contested privatisation and the constraints not with despair but with the documented case, the regulatory and legal challenge, and the mobilised community. And build the community, legal, and diaspora coalition over time, because in a rights-bearing territory these accumulate into real, winning power — as they have. A field tilted by privatisation and a fiscal board is worked through community power, the law, and the federal process, not through resignation to the status.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may not always win — a fossil contract may hold, a cleanup may slip, a development may proceed — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the privatisation, the fiscal board, and the status are real constraints. But here, more than in most places, the work is rarely wasted and the odds are genuinely favourable: the **harm was documented, the renewable law invoked, the cleanup pressed, the pollution reached, and the community and diaspora mobilised** — and Puerto Rico has proven, again and again, that a persistent, community-powered, law-grounded effort wins landmark victories. Press on through community power and the law; the island that forced the Navy out of Vieques and built its own solar in the mountains has shown that even the hardest fights can be won, and each effort builds the power and the precedent for the next.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In Puerto Rico, alongside the honest tilt of the privatisation and the fiscal board, there is a real dimension of corruption and capture, because the recovery and the energy contracts have at times been marked by opaque deals and favoured contractors — the notorious post-Maria contracting scandals are one example — and because the utility and government decisions have too often served private and outside interests over the ratepayers and communities who bear the cost. The harm here is partly the capture of the energy system, the recovery, and their benefits by the connected. Here, encouragingly, the response runs through genuinely powerful channels — the free press, the courts, the federal oversight and investigators, and the community power that has toppled the corrupt before.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

Here the capture is bound up with a debt crisis, a fiscal board, and a privatised utility, and its marks are specific: **opaque energy and recovery contracts favouring the connected, utility and government decisions serving private and outside interests, the ratepayers and communities bearing the cost, and the benefits of the recovery bypassing the people**. The task is to document it rigorously and reach it through the transparency, the courts, and the federal oversight, relying on the public records, the audits, the federal investigators, and the free press. And note that Puerto Rico's own recent history — the mass movement that toppled a governor — shows that the community can and does hold the corrupt to account.

Responding to Corruption — Through Transparency and Community Power

Where the corruption is real, the response runs through the transparency, the oversight, and the community power. Use the **public records and audits** to expose the opaque contracts and the capture. Use the **courts and the federal investigators and oversight** to reach the wrongdoing. Use the **free press** to make it visible. And use the **proven community power**, which has toppled the corrupt before, to demand accountability. Document rigorously, pursue it lawfully, and draw on the organising tradition, because in Puerto Rico exposure, litigation, and mobilisation are genuine and proven avenues. Route the effort through the transparency, the courts, the oversight, and the community.

A Note on Safety and Openness

This note is, encouragingly, a relatively light one, because Puerto Rico is a rights-bearing US territory where people can organise, litigate, speak, and publish freely, and where the courts, the free press, the federal agencies, and the diaspora are real and powerful. The work here can be done openly and vigorously. Exercise ordinary prudence — document carefully, act through the law and the institutions, build the broadest community and diaspora coalition — but do not mistake this for a place where advocacy must be hidden: it is a place with one of the proudest organising traditions in the hemisphere, where community power has won landmark victories against the US Navy and the fossil utilities alike. Handle the status question, the militarisation, and the partisan politics factually and with care, keeping the focus on the environment and the community. The openness and the proven power here are the great assets: use them fully and confidently, in the tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all through community power, the law, and the federal channels. Here is how they fit into a single Puerto Rican effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the harm-and-law file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the community-legal-and-diaspora coalition, organises the communities, the lawyers, and the diaspora. **Regulatory, energy, and environmental-justice** work presses the transition, the cleanup, and the coast. **Media**, free and resonant, carries the community-power-and-justice cause. The harm-and-law feeds all five at once — a documented case is a regulatory challenge, a federal push, a community mobilisation, and a diaspora appeal together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, through community power and the law, they compound into real, often winning defence of the energy future, the land, and the coast.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the harm and the law; identify the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, and the coast; build the community-legal-and-diaspora coalition and begin documentation. **Middle (months 2–18):** press the energy transition through the renewable law and community solar; press the Vieques cleanup and the coal-ash enforcement; and defend the coast and karst. **Later (months and years):** see the transition advanced, the cleanup pressed, the pollution reached, and the coast defended — real, winnable victories, as Vieques and Casa Pueblo achieved. A Puerto Rican effort works through community power and the law, and its fruits are genuine and often attainable; pace it accordingly, and draw on the proven tradition.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm and the law; press the energy transition through the renewable law and community solar; press the Vieques cleanup and address the legacy; reach the coal ash and pollution through federal law; defend the coast, karst, and access; use the community, legal, federal, and diaspora channels; and draw on the proven power.** The coalition that presses all five, through community power and the law and in the tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo, is the one that can genuinely defend the energy future, the land, and the coast — the kind of real, winnable result a US territory with a proven organising tradition allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive project in Puerto Rico is genuinely achievable, more so than in most places in this series, because Puerto Rico is a US territory with a proven organising tradition, access to federal environmental law, and real, recent environmental victories — even as the contested privatisation, the federal fiscal-control board, the territorial status, the slow recovery, and the transition's own pitfalls make the fights hard, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line. And yet the effort is far from futile — indeed the odds here are genuinely favourable — because the energy transition can be pressed through the island's own renewable law and its proven community solar, because Vieques shows a community can force out even the US Navy, because the coal ash and pollution can be reached through federal law, because the coast and karst can be defended, and because the organising tradition, the courts, the federal agencies, and the diaspora genuinely work; and those levers of the grid, Vieques, the coal ash, the coast, and the channels are real, powerful, and proven.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **Vieques proved a community can win even against the US Navy. Casa Pueblo proved a town can beat mining and build its own solar. The renewable law, the federal environmental law, and the diaspora are real, powerful levers. But the privatisation, the fiscal board, and the status constrain.** Hold both truths at once: real, powerful, proven levers of community power and the law, and the honest weight of a contested privatisation and a constraining status.

Above all, keep the discipline that gives these efforts their force. Document the harm and the law. Press the energy transition through the renewable law and community solar. Press the Vieques cleanup and address the legacy. Reach the coal ash and pollution through federal law. Defend the coast, karst, and access. Use the community, legal, federal, and diaspora channels. And draw on the proven power — because in a US territory with a proven organising tradition, an effort that defends the energy future, the land, and the coast through community power, the law, and the federal process, in the tradition of Vieques and Casa Pueblo, is one that is both effective and just.

Puerto Rico is a Caribbean island of mountains and karst and coast, a territory of US citizens who have endured the longest blackout in their nation's history, the legacy of decades of bombing on Vieques, and the pollution of an ageing industrial south, and who have answered with one of the proudest traditions of community environmental victory in the hemisphere. This guide has hidden none of the difficulty — the contested privatisation, the constraining fiscal board, the limiting status, the slow recovery, the transition's own hazards — and there is no pretending the fights are easy. But this is an island that forced the United States Navy to stop bombing Vieques, that beat back open-pit mining in the mountains and built its own solar future at Casa Pueblo, that filled the streets to topple a corrupt governor, and that keeps the lights on with rooftop panels when the grid fails. Those are the levers, and they are real and proven: the island's own renewable law and its community solar; the federal environmental law and the courts; the Superfund process turned to the unfinished cleanup; and the organising tradition, the free press, and the vast diaspora that have won before. There are real constraints — the privatisation, the fiscal board, the status — and this

guide has named them throughout. But the energy future and the land and the coast of Puerto Rico are worth every effort, the levers that run through community power and the law are real and often winning, and the work of pressing the transition, the cleanup, and the coastal defence is one that Puerto Ricans — the communities, the organisers, the lawyers, and the diaspora — have proven they can do, and win. So can you.